Name: _____

New York State Testing Program

English Language Arts Test Session 1

Grade 5

Spring 2026

RELEASED QUESTIONS

Session 1

TIPS FOR TAKING THE TEST

Here are some ideas to help you do your best:

- Read the whole passage before you answer the questions. Most questions will only make sense after you read the whole passage.
- You might need to read the passage more than once to answer a question.
- Read each question carefully. Take your time.
- A question may include a quote from a passage. You might need to review both the quote and the whole passage to answer the question.

When you write your answers

- make sure to answer the whole question;
- use examples or details from the text;
- write in complete sentences; and
- use correct spelling, grammar, capitalization, and punctuation.

Directions

Read this story. Then answer questions 1 through 7.

Alberta lives in a small California town. She has made friends with new neighbors Edie and her mother, Ms. Whitman, who have moved to the town from Brooklyn, New York. The Whitmans have purchased the bed-and-breakfast business across the street from Alberta's house.

Excerpt from *The Only Black Girls in Town*

by Brandy Colbert

1 I usually have first-day jitters, but when I wake up on Monday, I don't feel nervous at all. Just excited. I think maybe it's because I'm starting seventh grade—which isn't as great as eighth grade, but not nearly as bad as sixth. I had a stomachache a whole twenty-four hours before I started school last year. But, really, I think I feel better because Edie is here now.

2 Normally I'd ride my bike, but Ms. Whitman offered to drive us both since she has to fill out paperwork for Edie, so I ride with them. Dad looked relieved that it's one less thing he has to worry about, since Denise will be here soon and he's still trying to get her room ready.

3 The B&B is total chaos when I walk over to wait. The front door is cracked, so I peek my head in. The same NPR show my dad listens to every morning is playing loudly in the front room. "Hello?" I call out over the radio voices when I don't see anyone.

B&B = Bed-and-Breakfast, a private home where people can stay while on vacation

NPR = National Public Radio, a nonprofit media organization

4 A loud series of crashes comes echoing out from the kitchen.

5 "Alberta, is that you?" Ms. Whitman replies over the noise. It sounds like an entire cabinet of dishes just fell to the floor. "We'll be ready in two minutes! Do you want some water? Orange juice?"

GO ON

6 "No, thank you . . . Do you need some help?"

7 "Oh, I'm just fine, honey. Be right there!"

8 From upstairs, Edie yells down, "Mom, have you seen my black jeans?"

9 "You just had them on yesterday!" Ms. Whitman yells back.

10 "No, my *other* jeans!" Edie cries.

11 Five minutes later, I'm sitting in the back seat of Ms. Whitman's car while she verbally checks off all the things that should be in Edie's bag (tablet, pencils, pens, her new notebook, lunch money). Edie answers with a glazed doughnut stuffed in her mouth. Every time her mother stops at a red light and looks away, she picks up Ms. Whitman's travel mug and takes the tiniest sip of coffee.

12 Ewing Beach Middle School isn't as big as the elementary, with its sprawling front lawn and play area for recess. And it doesn't have a view of the beach, like the high school. But it's set up on a hill so you have to take dozens of steps or a long semicircle ramp to get to the top. I think it looks majestic, sitting up on the hill like that. Almost like a castle at the top of a mountain. Except it's not mysterious like a big stone castle, since the foyer is an atrium made of glass that lets you see everything. And there's certainly no royalty here.

foyer = the main entrance of a building

atrium = the main hall in a building

13 "You girls go on in and I'll figure out where to park and meet you inside," Ms. Whitman says as she gets to the front of the drop-off line.

14 Edie chews and swallows the last of her doughnut as we walk up the front path toward the stairs. "She is so not equipped for this." . . .

15 I don't know what to say to that, so we are silent as we make our way up the stairs with the rest of the students. I notice people giving Edie double takes. Whenever people stare at me, I think it's because I look different from most people in town. I hate that feeling—that someone is surprised to see a black person. Like we don't belong in certain areas just because no one was expecting us.

16 But I forget that Edie is new. A new kid in school is always exciting around here since not many people move to live in Ewing Beach year-round. Maybe they are looking because Edie is black and they weren't expecting to see her. But the looks are curious more than anything else. And Edie doesn't look like anyone else around here, with her dark lipstick, a long-sleeved black dress with a white collar and cuffs, and her black combat boots. (The other black jeans never did turn up this morning.)

17 Edie acts like she doesn't even notice people staring at her. She breezes through the doors like she owns the place. My stomach flutters and I feel those jitters settling in, right on time. I hope they don't turn into a stomachache. How is the new girl more comfortable than I am when she's only just gotten here?

1 What is the **main** way paragraphs 8 through 11 develop the story?

A by introducing Edie's mother

B by suggesting a possible conflict

C by introducing Edie's character

D by describing the drive to school

2 Which detail from the story **best** supports the narrator's claim that she feels different from others in school?

A "I don't know what to say to that, so we are silent as we make our way up the stairs . . ." (paragraph 15)

B "Like we don't belong in certain areas just because no one was expecting us." (paragraph 15)

C "A new kid in school is always exciting around here . . ." (paragraph 16)

D "But the looks are curious more than anything else." (paragraph 16)

3 In paragraphs 12 through 17, how does the setting affect the plot?

A by showing why Edie feels confident

B by introducing the characters Edie and Alberta

C by describing why Alberta is nervous

D by demonstrating why Edie and Alberta are friends

4 Which theme is **best** supported in paragraphs 16 and 17?

A Unfamiliar situations are often difficult for people.

B Communication between friends is sometimes silent.

C Friendship helps people during difficult times.

D Some people appear confident wherever they are.

5 Read this sentence from paragraph 17.

My stomach flutters and I feel those jitters settling in, right on time.

Which statement **best** describes the narrator's feelings in this sentence?

A She is used to feeling uneasy when going to school.

B She is concerned about how the students will treat Edie.

C She is worried about having to attend a new school.

D She is upset that Edie is receiving most of the attention.

6 Which detail would be **most** important to include in a summary of the story?

A "Normally I'd ride my bike, but Ms. Whitman offered to drive us . . ." (paragraph 2)

B "It sounds like an entire cabinet of dishes just fell . . ." (paragraph 5)

C "Edie chews and swallows the last of her doughnut . . ." (paragraph 14)

D "How is the new girl more comfortable than I am . . ." (paragraph 17)

7 The narrator **mainly** helps the reader understand Edie by describing

A Edie's response to the students who look at her

B why a pair of jeans is important to Edie

C Edie's decision to wear combat boots at school

D how Edie takes sips of her mother's coffee

Directions

Read this article. Then answer questions 15 through 21.

Excerpt from "Looking for Mushrooms"

by Cheryl Bardoe

1 Armed with a magnifying glass, pocketknife, and fishing tackle box, mushroom scientist Greg Mueller sets out on a treasure hunt. "I never know what I might find," he says, striking out along a woodland path at the Chicago Botanic Garden. "And what I find today may be different four days from now."

2 After decades as a mycologist (a scientist who studies fungi), Mueller knows that mushrooms are here-today, gone-tomorrow treasures. He jokes about becoming a geologist some day, "because rocks never move." But he isn't really discouraged. He knows that forests are full of fungi.

A World of Fungi

3 Fungi (one fungus, many fungi) are living things that are not animals or plants. They take many forms. They include the yeast that makes bread rise, the fuzzy mold on an old jar of spaghetti sauce, bathroom mildew, lichens on trees, and the mushrooms that pop up overnight in the grass.

4 For a long time, scientists thought fungi were plants, because they grow in soil and don't move. But fungi are not plants. They are very different. Unlike plants, fungi don't make their own food from sunlight and air. Instead, they get food by digesting wood, leaves, and dead things. The cells of fungi are also unlike plants. Their cell walls are made from chitin, the same stuff that forms the outer shells of insects and crabs.

5 Scientists now put fungi in their own separate kingdom of life, next to plants and animals. They estimate that there may be more than 3 million species of fungi, though humans have found only about 100,000 so far.

Searching for the Invisible

6 Mueller keeps a hopeful eye on the forest floor. But fungi are all around, even when we don't see them.

7 Fungi grow in hair-like threads called hyphae. These strands spread through soil and rotting wood as the fungus feeds. A single strand is too small to see. But Mueller points out white spots on a fallen tree where many have massed together, making a white web called a mycelium. A mushroom is made of the same stuff—the solid mushroom shape is thousands of fine threads of hyphae, clumped together.

massed = formed

8 Soon, Mueller spots a clump of mushrooms hiding beneath the leaves. He carves off some dainty, brownish-orange shoots to store in his collecting box. Like apples on a tree, mushrooms are the fruit of the fungus. Back at the nature center, he will rest the top of the mushroom on a piece of paper to collect the tiny spores that fall from the gills. The color will help him identify the mushroom. Spores are like mushroom seeds. When they fall, they float away (or are carried by animals) and grow into new fungi.

9 Mushrooms wait patiently underground for just the right combination of moisture and temperature to pop up. "When conditions are right," Mueller says, "mushrooms swell with water like a water balloon. That gives them the pressure to burst out of the ground." Mushrooms can expand quickly, sometimes with enough force to push up through cement. Then they release their spores and may disappear again within a few days.

10 A single mushroom can release millions, even trillions, of tiny spores. So why isn't Earth overrun with fungi? Unlike plant seeds, spores aren't packed with their own food. To grow, they have to land in just the right place, on something they can use for food.

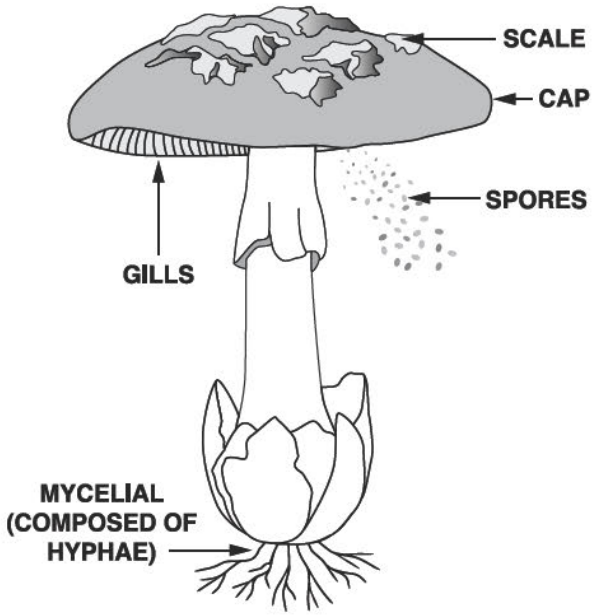
How Fungi Function

11 Some fungi are decomposers, breaking down old leaves and wood. Some form partnerships with living plants. And some are parasites.

12 Most mushrooms you might spot on a walk in the woods, from tiny fairy cups to big bracket fungi, are decomposers. As fungal hyphae spread through a fallen tree to gather food, they destroy the stiff cell walls of the wood. This frees the nutrients so other plants can use them. Mueller breaks a chunk of decaying wood from a tree, and it almost crumbles to sawdust in his fingers. That's a sign that fungi have done their work. "We'd have piles of dead trees miles high if we didn't have fungi," he says. "We wouldn't even be able to walk around the Earth because of all the dead trees."

13 Underground, many fungi make friends with trees and other plants. Tiny fungus threads are everywhere in soil. These grow around and into plant roots.

14 The fungal hyphae pull water and minerals from the soil, and pass some to the plant. In exchange, plants give the fungus some sugar they make. A tree's roots on their own often can't absorb enough minerals and water from the soil to grow big. But a fungus partner lets them reach farther and sip through more straws. Fungi often partner with many trees, and trees with many fungi, like a living internet underground. In the wild, almost all plants have fungus partners that help them grow.



15 In paragraph 8, why does the author refer to spores as being like "mushroom seeds"?

A to explain that spores can grow into mushrooms

B to emphasize the small size of most spores

C to describe how spores are moved by wind

D to explain that mushrooms grow underground

16 Read this claim from paragraph 2.

> **. . . Mueller knows that mushrooms are here-today, gone-tomorrow treasures.**

How do the details in paragraph 9 support this claim?

A by referring to the time mushrooms spend underground

B by describing how mushrooms swell with water

C by referring to some mushrooms that grow through cement

D by describing what happens after mushrooms release their spores

17 Which detail **best** represents a central idea of the article?

A "But fungi are all around, even when we don't see them." (paragraph 6)

B "A single strand is too small to see." (paragraph 7)

C "The color will help him identify the mushroom." (paragraph 8)

D "Unlike plant seeds, spores aren't packed with their own food." (paragraph 10)

18 Read this sentence from paragraph 12.

> **"We wouldn't even be able to walk around the Earth because of all the dead trees."**

What purpose does this sentence serve in the article?

A to highlight an important role that fungi play

B to explain why fungi burst out of the ground

C to describe how fungi spread over large areas

D to indicate a typical place where fungi are found

19 In the section titled "How Fungi Function," the author **best** develops the idea that fungi and plants help each other by

A describing the way fungi filter water in the soil

B showing how fungi spores help fruit to develop

C describing how fungi roots create food for insects

D showing how fungi and trees share their food

20 As used in paragraph 14, what does the phrase "like a living internet" suggest about hyphae and tree roots?

A Hyphae help provide trees with minerals.

B Hyphae and trees are connected in a vast system.

C Trees need hyphae to grow to larger sizes.

D Trees and hyphae require each other to survive.

21 In the article, what do both the author and the scientist agree is the **main** importance of fungi?

A their method of reproducing by releasing millions of spores

B the number of forms they take as well as the chitin in their cell walls

C their designation as a life form that is separate from plants and animals

D their role as decomposers as well as their partnerships with other life forms

Directions
Read this article. Then answer questions 22 through 28.

Excerpt from "Snow Machines: Venture Farther and Faster into the Wild on a Snowmobile"

by Aaron Derr

1 Just as there are different kinds of hiking, there are different kinds of snowmobiling.

2 Some sledheads are in it for the steep climbs. Others have the need for speed. And still others just like to use their snowmobiles to get away from it all, exploring areas that would be too difficult to access any other way.

3 That's Venturing Crew 115. In the warm-weather months, they travel from their homes near Snoqualmie, Washington, to paddle down their region's rivers and lakes in kayaks. . . .

> Venturing Crew 115 = a group of teens connected to the Boy Scouts of America that participates in outdoor activities

4 Each winter, they return to the same spot—near snow-covered Swan Lake Campground—for an event they call Snowcamp. With its thick, high brush, that spot would be terrible for camping during the summer.

5 During winter, with around 12 feet of snow, it's practically paradise.

Fall Preparation

6 Snowcamp is in the middle of February. But prep work starts months earlier.

7 In November and December, the crew hosts its most effective fundraiser: Christmas-tree sales. Proceeds help pay for the maintenance of their fleet of 24 snowmobiles.

8 After the holidays, the Venturers get to work on their sleds. Those snowmobiles aren't going to take care of themselves, after all. They call them work parties, and they have them three times a week. . . .

9 By late January or early February, the snowmobiles and crew are ready to go. The crew conducts training exercises on a snow-covered airfield. It's nice and flat and wide open—perfect for beginners and those who need to brush up on their skills. . . .

Winter Camping

10 Once the Venturers are comfortable on the equipment, they're ready for Snowcamp. They start by hauling the snowmobiles and camping gear as far as they can into the wilderness until the road ends.

11 From there, they board their machines with tow-behind equipment sleds and drive several miles farther. During their trek, they keep in touch with each other using two-way radios built into their helmets. When they get to their spot—about 5,000 feet above sea level—they begin setting up camp.

12 First, they mark the spot where they will have their fire. Then they mark a 40-foot diameter around that spot. Then they lay down a firewood platform and set firewood on top of that. As the fire burns, the platform drops deeper and deeper into the snow, at the rate of about 1 foot per hour.

13 In the meantime, the Scouts build a wall of ice blocks around the circle. (Imagine a 40-foot-wide igloo without a roof.) As the fire drops, the Venturers carve rows of stairs and benches into the snow.

14 After 12 or so hours, the fire has sunk down—surrounded by walls that are now more than 8 feet high and an icy bowl 12 feet deep. It's like a miniature coliseum, and it's the perfect winter shelter—protected from the wind and warmed by the fire. . . .

coliseum = large outdoor theater

Safety in the Snow

15 After spending the night in four-season tents and igloos, the Venturers spend the next day exploring the area on their snowmobiles. They often snowmobile up to a radio tower that offers sparkling views of the surrounding countryside. . . .

16 To stay warm, they dress in layers and wear noncotton clothing. If you don't like to wear wool, you don't get to go snowmobiling. The crew spends several weeks taking classes on proper winter clothing and how to stay warm in the cold environment. . . .

17 After three nights in the woods, the crew returns home. They are usually able to get back to the same spot the very next weekend for another three nights. If weather permits, they might have one more snowmobile trip in the spring.

18 Then they store the snowmobiles for the summer and look forward to the next year's Snowcamp.

Know Before You Go

WHERE:
Swan Lake Campground, near Snoqualmie Pass, Washington

WHEN:
Snowmobiling: January to March
Everything else: Every other month

WHAT:
The state of Washington has a very good snowmobiling trail maintenance program. But to get to the traditional camping spot, Crew 115 must venture a couple of miles off the trail. Don't try this at home without proper training and preparation.

SAFETY FIRST:
Before you plan a trip, learn the state laws for who can use snowmobiles, where you can use them, and how to become certified as an operator.

Check all your equipment before you start out.

Get the right clothing. Full-faced helmets are often required. Clothing must fit and protect against snow, water, and cold. High-tech headwear, footwear, and gloves are recommended.

Source: *Boys' Life* magazine, January 2017, © 2017 Boy Scouts of America

22 Which detail from the article **best** supports the claim in paragraph 2 that members of Venturing Crew 115 enjoy going to places that are difficult to reach?

A "After the holidays, the Venturers get to work on their sleds. Those snowmobiles aren't going to take care of themselves, after all." (paragraph 8)

B "The crew conducts training exercises on a snow-covered airfield. It's nice and flat and wide open—perfect for beginners and those who need to brush up on their skills." (paragraph 9)

C "They start by hauling the snowmobiles and camping gear as far as they can into the wilderness until the road ends." (paragraph 10)

D "The crew spends several weeks taking classes on proper winter clothing and how to stay warm in the cold environment." (paragraph 16)

23 Which statement **best** describes how the word choice in paragraphs 4 and 5 reflects the tone of the whole article?

A The explanation that the Venturers go "to the same spot" in paragraph 4 reflects the comfortable tone of the article.

B The description of the natural "thick, high brush" in paragraph 4 reflects the peaceful tone of the article.

C The explanation that there is "12 feet of snow" in paragraph 5 reflects the anxious tone of the article.

D The description of the Venturers' wild campsite as a "paradise" in paragraph 5 reflects the positive tone of the article.

24 How are the details in paragraph 12 connected to the details in paragraph 14?

A by showing the first and last steps in the process of building the Venturers' shelter

B by describing the problem with shelter building and the solution the Venturers found

C by contrasting different methods the Venturers have used to build their shelter

D by explaining how the Venturers' process of building a shelter has changed over time

25 Which detail from the article **most likely** reveals the author's opinion about the Venturers' campsite?

A "When they get to their spot—about 5,000 feet above sea level—they begin setting up camp." (paragraph 11)

B "As the fire burns, the platform drops deeper and deeper into the snow, at the rate of about 1 foot per hour." (paragraph 12)

C "It's like a miniature coliseum, and it's the perfect winter shelter—protected from the wind and warmed by the fire." (paragraph 14)

D "They are usually able to get back to the same spot the very next weekend for another three nights." (paragraph 17)

26 Which sentence **best** states a central idea of the article?

A Places where it is difficult to camp often make excellent spots for snowmobiling.

B Venturing Crew 115 has to work hard to enjoy being at Snowcamp.

C Snowmobiling can sometimes be dangerous for people with a lack of training.

D Participating in Snowcamp requires special clothing to protect against the cold.

27 Washington State law requires that all people aged 12 through 16 must pass a Snowmobile Safety Course before they drive a snowmobile. How does this idea connect with the details in the article?

A It explains that Snowcamp is attended by relatively few people because of the strict rules.

B It shows that the Venturers do the same amount of work as other people to learn snowmobiling.

C It supports the idea that people in Washington State take pride in its snowmobiling opportunities.

D It supports the idea that snowmobiling can be dangerous and requires practice and skill.

28 **This question is worth 2 credits.**

How do the details in the section "Fall Preparation" support a central idea of the article? Include your claim and use **two** details from the article to support your response.

STOP

Name: _____

New York State Testing Program

English Language Arts Test Session 2

Grade 5

Spring 2026

RELEASED QUESTIONS

Session 2

TIPS FOR TAKING THE TEST

Here are some ideas to help you do your best:

- Read the whole passage before you answer the questions. Most questions will only make sense after you read the whole passage.
- You might need to read the passage more than once to answer a question.
- Read each question carefully. Take your time.
- A question may include a quote from a passage. You might need to review both the quote and the whole passage to answer the question.

When you write your answers

- make sure to answer the whole question;
- use examples or details from the text;
- write in complete sentences; and
- use correct spelling, grammar, capitalization, and punctuation.

For the last question in this test book, you may plan your writing on the Planning Page provided. However, do NOT write your final answer on the Planning Page. Write your final answer on the lined pages.

Directions

Read this story. Then answer questions 29 through 35.

This story takes place many years ago at a middle school, MBMS, when some students were first using intranets, or private computer networks, available to people at their school. The narrator, Erin, is helping her classmates in the school's Intranet Club.

Excerpt from *Click Here (To Find Out How I Survived Seventh Grade)*

by Denise Vega

1 Intranet Club was the BEST. My group hung on every word I said and learned HTML really fast. We were already putting some pages together because it turned out I knew the most about web design. Even more than the eighth graders. Our group was in charge of the "School Life" section, which included stuff like faculty interviews, awards, and a page called "A Day in the Life" where we profiled a few kids, then typed up a journal, which everyone would get to read once the Intranet was live online.

HTML = coding language for the web

2 The only boring thing we had to do was list the courses and descriptions offered at MBMS, as well as the schedules for each track. But that only had to be done once, which was nice.

3 It also turned out that I was a pretty good leader when I knew what I was talking about. A couple of the eighth graders even asked me questions. And Tyler, formerly known as the Boy Who Wouldn't Take Instruction From Big Foot, was really into it and seemed to have forgotten all about thinking I was a dork. He asked me all kinds of questions and told me how smart I was.

4 "It's only because my mom's a web designer," I said modestly.

5 "Nah," Tyler said. "Even if both my parents were web designers, I wouldn't know the stuff you do."

6 I just smiled and showed him how to change the font size in his heading.

7 Mark's group was in charge of school events—arts and music, sports, and such. Not only did they list the events but they had reviewers and sportswriters covering each one. They had set it up like a newspaper, with digital photos and everything. Very cool.

8 "I can't log on. Why can't I log on?" Rosie sat at her computer, tapping angrily at the keyboard. "I have to get the letters to the editor ready by the end of the week." Rosie was in a group with an eighth-grade team leader, and they were in charge of all correspondence we received. This could be letters to the editor, letters for the weekly "Tell Us About It" column, or webmaster comments or complaints. Since we weren't going live until just before Thanksgiving, we asked a few kids to write in with questions or comments, and Rosie would include these in her first "Tell Us About It" column. Once we were live and the whole school had access to the Intranet, any student could send in a question or comment.

9 "We need a different name," I said during our break. Mark, Rosie, Tyler, and I were heading for the gym to shoot baskets. " 'Intranet Club' is boring."

10 "Yeah," said Mark. "What about Web Club? We could be the Webbies."

11 "The Webbies?" Rosie, Tyler, and I said it at the same time, raising our eyebrows at him.

12 "Okay, so that was stupid," Mark said, laughing.

13 "What about the I-Club?" I said. "The letter I."

14 "The I-Club," Rosie said. "Cool."

15 "People might think we're reading eye charts and stuff," Mark said.

16 "Not people in the know," I said.

29 Paragraphs 1 and 3 contribute to the story by

A foreshadowing events that will happen later

B providing details that develop the main character

C explaining the problem that the characters will solve

D describing events that happened at an earlier time

30 The word "modestly" in paragraph 4 suggests that the narrator

A does not want to point out her own talents

B does not feel that Tyler is being honest

C gets teased by the others in her group

D gets help from her family on her project

31 What does the phrase "going live" mean as it is used in paragraph 8 of the story?

A making the content available to all

B announcing the project to the school

C requesting feedback from others

D accessing the new computer system

32 What is the narrator's opinion about the club's name?

A It should be decided by the leader.

B It should be a secret to students.

C It should be more exciting.

D It should be easier to understand.

33 How are the narrator and Rosie similar?

A They both get annoyed at the computers the Intranet Club uses.

B They are both interested in telling the school about the Intranet Club.

C They both take their responsibilities in the Intranet Club seriously.

D They are both worried that the Intranet Club interferes with their sports.

34 Which sentence **best** states a theme of the story?

A Working together can make people feel closer.

B Completing a task can cause a feeling of pride.

C Asking for help can be difficult.

D Trying something new can be frightening.

35 This story takes place at a time years ago when computers were not common in classrooms and very few students were taught programming skills. How does this information help develop an important idea about the characters in the story?

A Students in the Intranet Club are all patient people who work well with others because they have to share the few computers available to them.

B Students in the Intranet Club are all exceptional because they try an activity that is new, difficult, and unknown by other students at their school.

C Students in the Intranet Club are all very mature because they choose to work with computers knowing that it will help them in their future careers.

D Students in the Intranet Club are persuasive people because they are able to convince their schools to try new technology before it is widely accepted.

Directions

Read this poem. Then answer questions 36 and 37.

An "ode" is a lyrical poem that expresses praise or tribute. This ode is about raspados, *which is the Spanish word for snow cones.*

"Ode to Los Raspados" from *Neighborhood Odes*

by Gary Soto

Papá says
They were
A shiny dime
When he was
Little, but for me,
His daughter
With hair that swings
Like jump ropes,
They're free:
Papá drives a truck
Of *helados* and
Snow cones, the
Music of arrival
Playing block
After block.

helados = Spanish word for ice cream

It's summer now.
The sun is bright
As a hot dime.
You need five
Shiny ones
For a snow cone:
Strawberry and root beer,
Grape that stains
The mouth with laughter,
Orange that's a tennis ball
Of snow
You could stab
with a red-striped straw.
We have
Green lime
And dark cola,
And we have
An umbrella of five colors.
When the truck stops,
The kids come running,
Some barefoot,
Some in T-shirts
That end at the
Cyclone knot
Of belly buttons
Some in swimming
Trunks and dripping
Water from a sprinkler
On a brown lawn.

I'm twelve going
On thirteen,
And I know what's what
When it comes to
Snow cones
Packed with the flat
Of a hand and laced
With a gurgle
Of sugary water.
I know the rounds
Of the neighborhood
I know the kids,
Gina and Ofélia,
Juan and Ananda,
Shorty and Sleepy,
All running
With dimes pressed
To their palms,
Salted from play
Or mowing the lawn.
When they walk away,
The dime of sun
Pays them back
With laughter
And the juice runs
To their elbows,
Sticky summer rain
That sweetens the street.

36 **This question is worth 2 credits.**

Why is the setting important to "Ode to Los Raspados"? Include your claim and use **two** details from the poem to support your response.

37 **This question is worth 2 credits.**

The author Henry James once said, "Summer afternoon—summer afternoon; to me those have always been the two most beautiful words in the English language." In the poem "Ode to Los Raspados," how does the speaker develop this idea? Include your claim and use **two** details from the poem to support your response.

Directions

Read this story. Then answer questions 38 and 39.

Excerpt from *The Battle of the Snow Cones*

by Lupe Ruiz-Flores

1 It was so hot in Caliente, Texas, the flowers drooped, the grass withered and the townspeople gulped down gallons of lemonade all day long. Even the dog jumped into the swimming pool. Ten-year-old Elena poured a bucket of water over her head. Her mother fanned herself day and night, but couldn't stay cool.

2 Then Elena had an idea.

3 "I think an icy snow cone will cool the neighbors down in this heat," Elena told her mother, who was sitting next to her.

4 "What an excellent idea," Mamá said. . . .

5 Elena went ahead with her plan. Papá built a wooden booth for the snow cone stand using some old lumber he had stored in the shed. Elena helped paint it sky blue. Papá borrowed the ice shaver machine that he used in the concession stand during church festivals. He showed Elena how to use it to make crushed ice for the snow cones. Mamá ordered a big block of ice and set it in a huge cooler on a table inside the booth. . . .

6 Elena chose strawberry, lemon, bubble gum and grape-flavored syrup for the snow cones. She set up the bottles of syrup in a neat row across the front counter so everyone could see them. Papá nailed a big sign to the front of her stand. It read, "SNOW CONES—75 cents." On the same sign, Elena drew and colored an inviting picture of a snow cone.

7 That afternoon, children and grownups alike lined up to buy the frosty delights. The lines grew longer and longer. Elena saw Alma watching from across the street.

8 By the following morning, Alma, with the help of her parents, set up a snow cone stand in her own front yard. Alma decorated it with dozens of pink, purple and yellow crepe paper flowers. Elena saw her customers drifting over to Alma's festive stand.

9 Mine will be better, Elena thought, as she hung blue, green and orange tissue paper cutouts across the front of her stand.

10 "Oh, look at the *papel picado*," one customer said, pointing to the colorful banner on Elena's stand. Soon, lots of people strolled back to her stand. . . .

papel picado = colorful paper banner

11 The following week, Elena ordered more ice and more snow cone flavors. So did Alma. The iceman delivered bigger and bigger blocks of ice as the two girls furiously shaved ice, day in and day out, competing for customers. Then one day, Alma heard a loud WHRUMP coming from her ice machine. . . .

12 Then another WHRUMP came from across the street. . . .

13 Horrified, the two girls watched as the crushed ice overflowed, spilled out of the machines, knocked over their stands and toppled the bottles of syrup onto the ground. Lemon, strawberry, mango, lime, bubble-gum syrup and all the other flavors leaked out of the bottles and mixed with the ice, which slid down the street, creating an enormous mound of ice at the bottom of the hill. The line of customers disappeared as they gleefully slid down the icy slope.

14 "Now, see what you've done," Alma said, scowling. "You drove all my customers away!"

15 "Me?" replied an angry Elena. "It was you who started all this. Instead of snow cones, we have a . . ."

16 "A giant rainbow snow cone," Alma said, finishing Elena's sentence. They both stared at the ribbons of color cascading down the dazzling ice mound. . . .

17 Elena pulled Alma out of the chair. "What are we waiting for?"

18 "You mean we're still friends?"

19 "Sure we are," replied Elena. "We'll always be friends."

20 Eager to join in the fun, they ran into the garage and emerged with cardboard sleds. They made their way up the snow cone hill with all the other children, waited their turn and then slid all the way down.

38 **This question is worth 2 credits.**

In *The Battle of the Snow Cones*, how does the narrator help the reader understand why Elena is upset with Alma? Include your claim and use **two** details from the story to support your response.

39 **This question is worth 4 credits.**

What is a theme shared by "Ode to Los Raspados" and *The Battle of the Snow Cones*? How is the development of this theme similar in the poem and the story? Use details from **both** the poem and the story to support your response.

In your response, be sure to

- identify a theme shared by the poem and the story
- explain how the development of this theme is similar in the poem and the story
- use details from **both** the poem and the story to support your response

STOP